

Relativity and Cosmology II Lecture Note

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Abstract

This is the lecture note of the GR 2 course in EPFL 2026 spring semester.

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1 Lecture 1: FRW Metric

For a cosmological model, we need to make some assumptions about the universe. The most common assumption is the cosmological principle:

Theorem 1.1

Cosmological Principle

The universe is homogeneous and isotropic on large scales.

The cosmological principle strongly constrains the form of the metric. We assume that we can select a space slice at each time in some coordinate system, and consider the induced metric on each time slice.

1.1 Space Slices Metric

The cosmological principle requires that the metric on each time slice is homogeneous and isotropic, which means that the metric on each time slice is a maximally symmetric space. A maximally symmetric space is a space that has the maximum number of symmetries, which means that the Riemann curvature tensor has the following form:

$$\begin{aligned} R^{(3)} &= \text{constant} \\ R_{ij} &= \frac{1}{3} R^{(3)} g_{ij} \\ R_{ijkl} &= \frac{1}{6} R^{(3)} (g_{ik} g_{jl} - g_{il} g_{jk}) \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

Thus we can see that a spacial metric can be classified into three types, and in fact each type of metric can be written in a simple form:

- $R^{(3)} = 0$, the metric is $\mathbb{R}^3$ 3-plane
- $R^{(3)} > 0$, the metric is $\mathbb{S}^3$ 3-sphere
- $R^{(3)} < 0$, the metric is $\mathbb{H}^3$ 3-hyperbolic space (Euclidean AdS space)

The metric of $\mathbb{R}^3$ is trivial, we will consider the other two cases in the following:

1.1.1 $\mathbb{S}^3$ 3-sphere

The metric of a 3-sphere can be given by inducing from a 4-dimensional Euclidean space with Cartesian coordinates x^i and the metric $ds^2 = \delta_{ij} dx^i dx^j$. We can induce a coordinate and metric by the following constraint and parametrization:

- Constraint: $\sum_i x_i^2 = a^2$
- Parametrization:

$$\begin{aligned} x_1 &= R \sin \theta \cos \varphi \\ x_2 &= R \sin \theta \sin \varphi \\ x_3 &= R \cos \theta \\ x_4 &= \sqrt{a^2 - R^2} \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

The induced metric is given by:

$$ds^2 = \frac{a^2 dr^2}{a^2 - r^2} + r^2 d\Omega_2^2 \tag{3}$$

We can calculate the Ricci Scalar of this metric, and we find that $R^{(3)} \sim \frac{1}{a^2}$.

1.1.2 $\mathbb{H}^3$ 3-hyperbolic space

Similarly we can embed the 3-hyperbolic space into a 4-dimensional Minkowski space with Cartesian coordinates x^i to get the metric. Another easy way of seeing the result is simply take the metric of the 3-sphere and replace a^2 with $-a^2$. This will definitely give us a solution to the constraints Equation 1 with negative curvature. Thus we can write the metric of the 3-hyperbolic space as:

$$ds^2 = \frac{a^2 dr^2}{a^2 + r^2} + r^2 d\Omega_2^2 \quad (4)$$

1.1.3 Unified Form of Spacial Metric

With above preparations, we can write three types of metrics in a unified form:

$$ds^2 = a^2 \left(\frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2 d\Omega_2^2 \right) \quad (5)$$

Here $k = -1, 0, 1$ stands for the three types of metrics. $k = 1$ gives $\mathbb{S}^3$ and $k = -1$ gives $\mathbb{H}^3$.

1.2 FRW Metric

1.2.1 Definition in Comoving Coordinates

With the spacial slice metric prepared, we can add a time coordinate to make it a full 4 dimensional metric ansatz. A typical form of the metric is given by:

Definition 1.2

FRW Metric

The FRW metric is given by:

$$\begin{aligned} ds^2 &= -dt^2 + a^2(t) \left(\frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2 d\Omega_2^2 \right) \\ &= -dt^2 + a^2(t) \gamma_{ij} dx^i dx^j \end{aligned} \quad (6)$$

Mathematically, we can rigorously show that the FRW metric is the only metric that satisfies the cosmological principle. Physically, we can also understand that the FRW metric is the most general metric that can describe a homogeneous and isotropic universe.

Remark

However, we shall notice that such metric is only defined on a patch of the manifold. Different manifold with different topology can have the same local metric. Thus, the global structure of the spacetime is undetermined.

1.2.2 Unit of the Scale Factor

We can see that:

- For $k \neq 0$;, the scale factor $a(t)$ has the physical meaning of radius of spacial curvature. Thus, we can assign it a unit of length and take the spacial coordinate dimensionless.
- For $k = 0$: the scale factor $a(t)$ can be taken as dimensionless, and the spacial coordinate can be taken as having a unit of length.

In fact in this case, at fixed time, $a(t = t_0)$ is meaningless, what physical is the ratio $\frac{a(t)}{a(t_0)}$.

1.2.3 Remark on Comoving Coordinates

[Definition 1.2](#) is certainly written in a certain coordinate system, which is called the **comoving coordinates**. This means that the particles at rest in this frame (at rest means at rest spacially and moving in the time coordinate) are free (which means they move in geodesics) We can see that indeed $u^0 = 1$ is a solution to the geodesic equation.

1.2.4 Connection and Curvature

We can calculate the Levi-Civita connection and the curvature of the FRW metric in the comoving coordinates:

- Metric:

$$g_{00} = -1, \quad g_{ij} = a^2 \gamma_{ij} \quad g^{00} = -1, \quad g^{ij} = a^{-2} \gamma^{ij} \quad (7)$$

- Curvature:

$$\begin{aligned} R_{00} &= -3 \frac{\ddot{a}}{a} \quad R_{0i} = 0 \\ R_{ij} &= (a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2k) \gamma_{ij} \\ R &= 6 \frac{a\ddot{a} + \dot{a}^2 + k}{a^2} \end{aligned} \quad (8)$$

where γ_{ij} is the spacial metric. We can see that the curvature is determined by the scale factor $a(t)$ and the curvature parameter k .

2 Lecture 2: Friedmann Equations and Solutions

We can rewrite the Einstein Field Equations with two ansatz:

- The metric is given by the Friedmann-Robertson-Walker (FRW) metric
- The EM tensor of matter is given by a perfect fluid in the comoving frame

2.1 Einstein Field Equations

We consider the general Einstein Field Equation with a cosmological constant:

$$R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2}Rg_{\mu\nu} + \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi GT_{\mu\nu} \quad (9)$$

2.1.1 Matter Energy-Momentum Tensor in Comoving Frame

In Section 1.2.4 we have calculated the curvature tensor in the comoving frame, which is the LHS of Equation 9. Now we need to calculate the EM tensor of matter in the comoving frame. We focus on:

- The matter is a perfect fluid and being at rest in the comoving frame

which means that the EM tensor has the following form in the comoving frame:

$$T_{\mu\nu} = u_\mu u_\nu (\rho + p) + pg_{\mu\nu} \quad (10)$$

And we assume that the matter is at rest in the comoving frame, which means that the 4-velocity is given by $u^\mu = (1, 0, 0, 0)$. Thus we have the only non-zero component of the EM tensor is:

$$T_{00} = \rho, \quad T_{ij} = pg_{ij} \quad \text{or} \quad T^{00} = \rho, \quad T^{ij} = pg^{ij} = p \frac{\gamma^{ij}}{a^2} \quad (11)$$

Generally, the homogeneity and isotropy of the universe requires that the EM tensor $\rho(t), p(t)$ only depends on time. This suits that the metric is also only depends on time.

Normally, we assume that there is a relation between the energy density and pressure, depend on the matter itself. Thus, the EM tensor has only one degree of freedom, which is the energy density ρ .

2.1.2 Friedmann Equations

Now we can plug in the curvature tensor and the EM tensor into the Einstein Field Equation, and we can get the 00 component of the Einstein Field Equation, which is called the Friedmann Equation:

Theorem 2.1

Friedmann Equation

The Friedmann Equation is given by the 00 component of the EFE of a rest perfect fluid in the comoving frame, which is given by:

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 + \frac{k}{a^2} = \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho + \frac{\Lambda}{3} \quad (12)$$

Let's now count the variable and equations, usually we fix a k for the model we want to consider. Then, the EM Tensor have 1 DoF $\rho(t)$, the metric have 1 DoF $a(t)$, and we have 1 equation, which is the Friedmann Equation. Thus we need another equation to solve the system.

We first consider the other Terms of the Einstein Field Equation, which is the ij component. We can get another equation from the ij component of the EFE, which is given by:

Theorem 2.2

Spacial Component of EFE

The ij component of the EFE of a rest perfect fluid in the comoving frame is given by:

$$2\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} + \left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 + \frac{k}{a^2} = -8\pi Gp + \Lambda \quad (13)$$

Remark

We only have one spacial equation, this is due to the fact that the spacial metric is dependent on γ_{ij} up to one factor. Thus, the spacial component of the EFE only gives one equation.

Sometimes we combine the two equations together, and we can get rid of the term $\dot{a}$, which is :

$$\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}(\rho + 3p) + \frac{\Lambda}{3} \quad (14)$$

From this equation we can easily see when the universe is accelerating or decelerating. If we assume that $\Lambda = 0$ then:

- If $\rho + 3p > 0$ then the universe is decelerating $\ddot{a} < 0$
- If $\rho + 3p < 0$ then the universe is accelerating $\ddot{a} > 0$

2.1.3 Energy Conservation of Matter

Another commonly used choice of the second equation is the energy conservation of matter. Note that this equation is not independent of EFE, since it is given by EFE and the Bianchi Identity.

Theorem 2.3

Energy Conservation of Matter

The energy conservation of matter is given by:

$$\partial_t(\rho a^3) + p\partial_t a^3 = 0 \quad (15)$$

We can see that the energy conservation is equivalent to the first law of thermodynamics, if we view the matter as a thermodynamic system with volume $V = a^3$ and internal energy $U = \rho a^3$.

2.2 Matter Content and Solutions

Now we try to find solutions to the EFE. But we need to specify the matter content exists in the universe.

2.2.1 Matter Content and Equation of State

We usually focus on Model behave as

$$P = \omega\rho \quad (16)$$

And usually the coefficient ω is given by:

- Pressureless Dust: $\omega = 0$
- Relativistic Fluid (Radiation): $\omega = \frac{1}{3}$
- Cosmological Constant: $\omega = -1$

We believe that $\omega \geq -1$ and cc is the lower bound, which is called the null energy condition.

Remark

We can see from the EFE that a matter with $\omega < -1$ gives out $\rho = \text{const}$ in the energy consevation of matter, this is equivalent to having a cosmological constant of $\Lambda = 8\pi G\rho$.

Btw, we may assume that $\rho > 0$ the matter have positive energy density. Thus, the “cosmological constant” case is in fact “positive cosmological constant” case.

2.2.2 Solution 1: Einstein Static Universe

If we assume that $\rho \neq 0$, $p = 0$; $\dot{a} = 0$. which means that the universe is full of pressureless dust and is static. Then the two EFE becomes:

$$\frac{k}{a^2} = \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho + \frac{\Lambda}{3}, \quad \frac{k}{a^2} = \Lambda \quad (17)$$

If we take a positive cosmological constant, then we can get the following solution:

$$k = 1 \quad a = \sqrt{\frac{1}{\Lambda}} \quad \rho = \frac{\Lambda}{4\pi G} \quad (18)$$

This solution is called the Einstein Static Universe, which is a static universe with positive curvature and a positive cosmological constant. However, this is unrealistic

2.2.3 Solution 2: Flat Matter Dominated Universe

We assume that $k = 0$, $\Lambda = 0$, and the universe is full of pressureless dust. Then the Friedmann Equation and the Energy Conservation of Matter becomes:

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho, \quad \partial_t(\rho a^3) = 0 \quad \text{or} \quad \rho a^3 = C \quad (19)$$

we can get a differential equation:

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3} \frac{C}{a^3} \quad (20)$$

The solution to this equation is given by:

$$a(t) = a_0(t - t_0)^{\frac{2}{3}} \quad \rho \sim \frac{1}{t^2} \quad (21)$$

We can notice that this solution $\dot{a} > 0$ and $\ddot{a} < 0$, which means that the universe is expanding and decelerating.

2.2.4 Solution 3: Flat General Matter Dominated Universe

Consider a more general case with $k = 0$, $\Lambda = 0$, and the matter content is given by a general equation of state $P = \omega\rho$. This time the Friedmann Equation and the Energy Conservation of Matter becomes:

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho, \quad \dot{\rho} + 3\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)(\rho + p) = 0 \quad (22)$$

This gives us a solution:

$$\rho = Ca^{-3(1+\omega)}, \quad a(t) = a_0(t - t_0)^{\frac{2}{3(1+\omega)}} \quad (23)$$

There are some special properties of this solution:

- **Null Energy Condition** : Notice that we believe that $\omega \geq -1$. Thus we can see that $a(t)$ will always have a singularity at $t = t_0$, for the metric in this coordinate.
- **Matter density time dependent** : We can see that if one kind of matter dominates the universes, then:

$$\rho \sim \frac{1}{t^2} \quad (24)$$

And if we have many kinds of matter and the effective ω is given by ω , then matter ρ_i evolve as:

$$\rho_i \sim t^{-2\frac{1+\omega_i}{1+\omega}} \quad (25)$$

- **Accelerating and Decelerating** : we can calculate $\ddot{a}$ and we see that:
 - If $\omega > -\frac{1}{3}$ then the universe is decelerating $\ddot{a} < 0$
 - If $\omega < -\frac{1}{3}$ then the universe is accelerating $\ddot{a} > 0$
- **Spacial Curvature as Matter**: An interesting observation is that having non-zero spacial curvature k is equivalent as choosing a matter of:

$$\omega = -\frac{1}{3} \quad (26)$$

Thus in fact we can view the spacial curvature as a kind of matter content in the universe. We can also see that this matter makes the universe not accelerating nor decelerating, $\ddot{a} = \text{const.}$

3 Lecture 3: Cosmological Horizons, dS Spacetime and Distance

3.1 Cosmological Horizons

We consider the Penrose diagram of a FRW metric, generally the metric can be written as:

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a(t)^2 dx^2 \quad (27)$$

Here we use dx^2 to represent the spacial metric. Then we can make a change of variables:

$$d\eta = \frac{dt}{a(t)} \quad (28)$$

Thus we can have the metric using (η, x) coordinate as:

$$ds^2 = a(\eta)^2 (-d\eta^2 + dx^2) \quad (29)$$

which is a conformally Minkowski metric. Then we need to fix the shape of the Penrose diagram. To do this we have to know what value can we take for η as t goes from $t_0 = 0$ to $t = +\infty$. We can integrate the relation Equation 28 and assume at $t = 0, \eta = \eta_*$:

$$\eta = \int_0^t \frac{dt'}{a(t')} + \eta_* \quad (30)$$

We assume that the space is flat and the spacetime is filled with $P = \omega\rho$ content. Then a general solution is:

$$a(t) \sim t^{\frac{2}{3(1+\omega)}} \quad (31)$$

Then we can see that $\omega > -\frac{1}{3}$ and $\omega < -\frac{1}{3}$ gives two cases for the behavior of η as t goes to zero and infinity.

3.1.1 Case 1 : $\omega > -\frac{1}{3}$ decelerating universe

In the case, we can find that the integral Equation 30 converge at $t = 0$ but diverge at $t = +\infty$. we can choose a suitable η_* to make η go from η_* to $+\infty$, and at $t = 0, \eta = \eta_*$ the metric is singular. Thus the penrose diagram behave as:

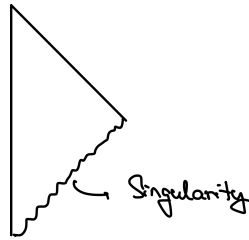


Figure 1: Penrose diagram for a decelerating universe with $\omega > -\frac{1}{3}$

3.1.2 Case 2: $\omega < -\frac{1}{3}$ accelerating universe

In this case, we find the integral Equation 30 diverge at $t = 0$ but converge at $t = +\infty$. This means that for an accelerating universe, we can choose a suitable η_* to make η go from $-\infty$ to a finite number and at $t = 0, \eta = -\infty$ there is a singularity. Thus the penrose diagram be like:

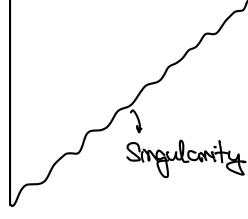


Figure 2: Penrose diagram for an accelerating universe with $\omega < -\frac{1}{3}$

We can see that in this case, there exist something called a **Cosmological Horizon**. It is originate from the fact that two points in the spacetime can never send information to each other, for the light can never reach each other before touching the future infinity.

This is interpret as the Universe is accerlating in expanding, thus the light can never catch up with the expansion of the universe.

3.2 De Sitter Spacetime

3.2.1 Cosmological Constant Case with Flat Spatial Curvature

We now focus on a special case of $k = 0, \Lambda = 0$ universe with the matter content of $\omega = -1$ which is the cosmological constant case. Or equivalently $\Lambda \neq 0, \rho = 0$. Note that it is not include in the general matter case Section 2.2.4, since the solution is distinct.

In this case, the Friedmann Equation and Energy Conservation of Matter becomes:

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 = \frac{\Lambda}{3}, \quad \rho = \text{const} := \frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} \quad (32)$$

Thus we can get the solution that:

$$a(t) = \exp(Ht), \quad H = \sqrt{\frac{\Lambda}{3}}, \quad (33)$$

This solution we can see that t goes from $-\infty$ to $+\infty$. There is a singularity at $t = -\infty$ where $a(t) = 0$.

Remark

Here we take a convention that $a_0 = 1$ and in fact there are two solutions e^{Ht} and e^{-Ht} . We can choose the solution e^{Ht} since it is more physical, which means that the universe is expanding. The other solution e^{-Ht} is a contracting universe, and singularity at $t = +\infty$ where $a(t) = 0$. However, this solution is not physical since we believe that the universe is expanding, thus we can discard this solution.

3.2.2 Penrose Diagram

We can make a change of variable:

$$\eta = \int \frac{dt}{a(t)} = -\frac{e^{-Ht}}{H} \quad (34)$$

Thus we can get the metric in the (η, x) then the metric becomes:

$$ds^2 = \frac{a_0^2}{H^2 \eta^2} (-d\eta^2 + dx^2) \quad (35)$$

we can see the range of the parameter η :

- as $t \rightarrow \infty$ $\eta \rightarrow 0^-$ which is far future.
- as $t \rightarrow -\infty$ $\eta \rightarrow -\infty$ which is the past singularity.

Thus the penrose diagram of this spacetime is like:

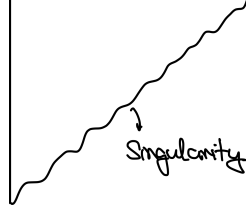


Figure 3: Penrose diagram for cosmological constant case with $\omega < -1$

which behaves just like the accerlating universe case in the general matter solution Figure 2.

3.2.3 Global de Sitter Spacetime

However, the singularity we get at $t = -\infty$ is not a real singularity!! These can be seen by the behavior of the curvature. We can prove that the curvature is a constant and don't have any singularity at $t = -\infty$. Thus, we expect we can do an extension of the spacetime to get rid of this coordinate singularity.

One approach to this is to investigate a seemingly different solution of the EFE, which is the **vaccum solution with $k = 1$** . The EFE reads:

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 + \frac{1}{a^2} = \frac{\Lambda}{3}, \quad 2\left(\frac{\ddot{a}}{a}\right) + \left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 + \frac{1}{a^2} = \Lambda \quad (36)$$

The solution to this equation is given by:

$$a(t) = H^{-1} \cosh(Ht), \quad H = \sqrt{\frac{\Lambda}{3}}, \quad (37)$$

This spacetime is called **Global dS Spacetime**.

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + H^{-2} \cosh^2(Ht)(d\chi^2 + \sin^2(\chi)d\Omega_2^2) \quad (38)$$

We can see that the metric is non-singular at any t for the cosh function is well behaved and have no zero point. More importantly, we can prove:

- The cosmological constant case with flat spatial curvature is a patch of the global dS spacetime, which is called the **Poincare Patch**.

In penrose diagram, this can be shown as:

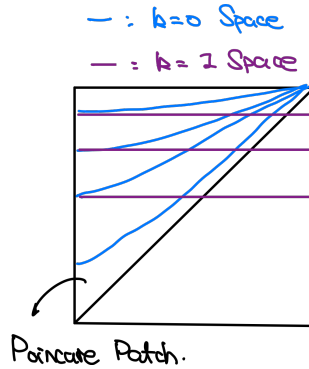


Figure 4: Penrose diagram for the global dS spacetime, where the blue region is the Poincare patch which is the cosmological constant case with flat spatial curvature

We can see that the blue line is a spacial slicing that make the spacial metric flat, yet the price to pay is that it only cover a patch of the global dS spacetime.

3.3 Hubble Parameter and General Evolution of the Universe

We recap on the three equations we commonly use for solving EFE:

$$\begin{aligned} \left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 + \frac{k}{a^2} &= \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho + \frac{\Lambda}{3}, \quad \text{Friedmann Equation} \\ 2\left(\frac{\ddot{a}}{a}\right) + \left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 + \frac{k}{a^2} &= -8\pi Gp + \Lambda, \quad \text{Spacial EFE} \\ \dot{\rho} + 3\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)(\rho + p) &= 0 \quad \text{Energy Conservation of Matter} \end{aligned} \tag{39}$$

If we consider a certain kind of matter $p_i = \omega_i \rho_i$, the enegy conservation gives us:

$$\rho_i = C a^{-3(1+\omega_i)}, \quad p_i = \omega_i \rho_i \tag{40}$$

Moreover, we can define a parameter:

Definition 3.1

Hubble Parameter

The **Hubble Parameter** is defined as:

$$H = \frac{\dot{a}}{a} \tag{41}$$

Thus the Friedmann Equation with $k = 0, \Lambda = 0$ can be written as:

$$H^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3} \sum_i \rho_i \tag{42}$$

Further more we can define a parameter called **Critical Density** if we use the energy density of **today** as a reference:

Definition 3.2

Critical Density

The **Critical Density** is defined as:

$$\rho_c = \frac{3H_0^2}{8\pi G}, \quad \text{equivalently} \quad \rho_c = \sum_i \rho_i(t = t_0) \tag{43}$$

where H_0 is the Hubble Parameter at present time t_0 . And we can define Ω_i which is :

$$\Omega_i = \frac{\rho_i(t = t_0)}{\rho_c}, \quad \text{thus} \quad \sum_i \Omega_i = 1 \tag{44}$$

With all these preparation, we can rewrite the Friedmann Equation (with $k \neq 0, \Lambda \neq 0$ and with the energy conservation already used) as:

$$H^2 = H_0^2 \left(\Omega_\Lambda + \Omega_k \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^2 + \Omega_m \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^3 + \Omega_\gamma \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^4 \right) \tag{45}$$

The first two term is the contribution from the cosmological constant and the spatial curvature, and the last two term is the contribution from the matter and the radiation, with certain ω_i determine its behavior.

If we rewrite LHS back with $\frac{\dot{a}}{a}$ and we group terms we can get:

$$\dot{a}^2 = H_0^2 \left(\Omega_\Lambda a^2 + \Omega_k a_0^2 + \Omega_m \frac{a_0^3}{a} + \Omega_\gamma \frac{a_0^4}{a^2} \right) \quad (46)$$

Which can be interpreted as the equation of motion of a particle with zero total energy moving in a potential:

$$U(a) = -H_0^2 \left(\Omega_\Lambda a^2 + \Omega_k a_0^2 + \Omega_m \frac{a_0^3}{a} + \Omega_\gamma \frac{a_0^4}{a^2} \right), \quad \dot{a}^2 + U(a) = 0 \quad (47)$$

Why do we prefer this form of the EoM of the metric?

This is because parameters here are mostly observables that we can measure from looking into the sky.

- H_0 can be measured through measuring how stars go away from us. And therefore we can measure the critical density ρ_c .
- Ω_i can be measured by doing sky search, and seeing the energy density of different matter content in the universe.

3.4 Distances in Cosmology

To investigate the cosmology, we need to define the lengths.

3.4.1 Redshift

Assume a process, a star emit a light at $t = t_1, r = r_1$ and the light is observed by us at $t = t_0, r = 0$. The light travel along null geodesics:

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a(t)^2 \frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} = 0 \Rightarrow dt = -a(t) \frac{dr}{\sqrt{1 - kr^2}} \quad (48)$$

There is a “-” sign since the light is traveling from r_1 to 0. Thus we can get evaluate a length of the light travel $l(r)$:

$$\int_{t_1}^{t_0} \frac{dt}{a(t)} = \int_0^{r_1} \frac{dr}{\sqrt{1 - kr^2}} = l(r_1) \quad (49)$$

We can calculate the length $l(r)$ for different spatial curvature:

$$l(r) = \begin{cases} \arcsin(r) & k = 1 \\ r & k = 0 \\ \operatorname{arcsinh}(r) & k = -1 \end{cases} \quad (50)$$

Then we can consider a process of two light signal emit at $t = t_1$ and $t = t_1 + \delta t_1$ and the light is observed at $t = t_0$ and $t = t_0 + \delta t_0$. Since the two light signal travel along the same null geodesics, we can get:

$$\frac{\delta t_0}{a(t_0)} = \frac{\delta t_1}{a(t_1)} \quad (51)$$

The frequency of the light is inversely proportional to the time interval $\omega \propto \frac{1}{t}$, thus we can get:

$$\frac{\omega_0}{\omega_1} = \frac{\delta t_1}{\delta t_0} = \frac{a(t_0)}{a(t_1)} \quad (52)$$

- Universe is Expanding: $a(t_0) > a(t_1)$ thus $\omega_0 > \omega_1$ which is called **Redshift**.

- Universe is Contracting: $a(t_0) < a(t_1)$ thus $\omega_0 < \omega_1$ which is called **Blueshift**.

The redshift can be described by the following quantity:

Definition 3.3

Redshift

The **Redshift** is defined as:

$$z = \frac{\lambda_0 - \lambda_1}{\lambda_0} = \frac{a(t_0)}{a(t_1)} - 1 \quad (53)$$

note that t_0 is the time of getting the light and t_1 is the time of emitting the light.

Usually, we know the λ_1 of many processes, and we measure λ_0 from experiments. Thus, we can use z as a measure of the distance.

3.4.2 Physical Distance and Coordinate Distance

For two comoving objects at $r = r_1$ and $r = r_2$, the coordinate distance is:

$$l_c = l(r_1) - l(r_2) \quad (54)$$

which is the distance separated in the spacial coordinate. However, its not the distance in the general metric. The physical distance is given by:

$$l_p = a(t)(l(r_1) - l(r_2)) = a(t)l_c \quad (55)$$

We know that for a comoving object, the spacial coordinate is fixed when moving in geodesics. Yet, the physical distance is time dependent due to the $a(t)$ parameter:

$$\frac{dl_p}{dt} = \dot{a}l_c = Hl_p, \quad H = \frac{\dot{a}}{a} \quad (56)$$

This is the **Hubble Law**, which fits well with the observation of the universe, which is one of the evidences for the expanding universe.

Remark

We here have three notion of “length”:

- r , the spacial coordinate variable, which is NOT the coordinate distance.
- $l(r)$, the coordinate distance, which is the distance in the spacial metric.
- l_p , the physical distance, which is the distance in the full metric.

3.4.3 Luminosity Distance

We first define something as:

- **Standard Candle** : which is a object with known luminosity L , where $L = \frac{dE}{dt}$ is defined as the energy emitted by the object per unit time in the object’s rest frame.

Then we consider a comoving telescope observing the standard candle, we can define a quantity called **Luminosity Distance** as:

The **Luminosity Distance** is defined as:

$$P = L \frac{S}{4\pi d^2} \quad (57)$$

where P is the measured energy recieved per unit time by the telescope, and S is the area of the telescope. The luminosity distance d is defined as the distance that make the above equation hold.

Then we can calculate the luminosity distance and its relation with other quantities for a comoving telescope and star in the FRW metric set up.

In the FRW metric set up, the actual P can be calculated as:

$$P = L \left(\frac{S}{S_{\text{tot}}} \right) \left(\frac{\hbar\omega_0}{\hbar\omega_1} \right) \left(\frac{\delta t_1}{\delta t_0} \right) \quad (58)$$

Lets explain each term, we set convension of t_1 the time of emitting the light and t_0 the time of getting the light:

- L is the Energy emitted per unit time when the energy is emitted.
- S is the area of the telescope. S_{tot} is the total area of light front, due to the expansion of the universe it takes form of:

$$S_{\text{tot}} = 4\pi a(t_0)^2 r^2(t_1, t_0) \quad (59)$$

where $r(t_1, t_0)$ is the difference in coordinate r between the star and the telescope (which is NOT the coordinate distance), which follow the null geodesic equation as:

$$dt = -a(t) \frac{dr}{\sqrt{1 - kr^2}} \Rightarrow \int_{t_1}^{t_0} \frac{dt}{a(t)} = \int_0^r \frac{dr}{\sqrt{1 - kr^2}} \quad (60)$$

where r then is implicitly a function of t_1 and t_0 .

Remark

Why do this S_{tot} is the total area of the light front?

We can see this from the FRW metric [Definition 1.2](#), for a fixed time t_0 , and a fixed r , the area of the sphere is given by:

$$ds^2 = a^2(t_0) r^2 d\Omega_2^2 \quad (61)$$

we integrate over the angular coodiantes we can get the area of the sphere as:

$$S = 4\pi a^2(t_0) r^2 \quad (62)$$

- $\frac{\omega_0}{\omega_1}$ is the ratio of the frequency of the light when getting and emitting, which is given by the redshift as:

$$\frac{\omega_0}{\omega_1} = \frac{a(t_0)}{a(t_1)} \quad (63)$$

- $\frac{\delta t_1}{\delta t_0}$ is the time given by the difference of infinitesimal time changes. This is also given by the redshift, see Equation 51:

$$\frac{\delta t_1}{\delta t_0} = \frac{a(t_1)}{a(t_0)} \quad (64)$$

If we put all these together, we can get:

$$P = L \left(\frac{S}{S_{\text{tot}}} \right) \left(\frac{\hbar\omega_0}{\hbar\omega_1} \right) \left(\frac{\delta t_1}{\delta t_0} \right) = L \left(\frac{S}{4\pi a(t_0)^2 r^2} \right) \left(\frac{a(t_0)}{a(t_1)} \right) \left(\frac{a(t_1)}{a(t_0)} \right) = L \frac{S}{4\pi a(t_0)^2 r^2} \quad (65)$$

This gives us the luminosity distance as:

Corollary 3.5

Luminosity Distance in FRW Metric

The luminosity distance in the FRW metric is given by:

$$d = \frac{a(t_0)^2}{a(t_1)} r(t_1, t_0) = (1+z)a(t_0)r(t_1, t_0) \quad (66)$$

where z is the redshift, see [Definition 3.3](#).

3.5 Distances in Cosmology II

3.5.1 Luminosity Distance and Redshift

We want a formula for the luminosity distance d_L as a function of redshift z . Thus, if we both measure d_L and z then we can find measure parameter $a(t)$.

We start from the expression [Corollary 3.5](#), we can see that $r(t_0, t_1)$ can be calculated using the null geodesic Equation 60, using the result of Equation 50 gives:

$$r(t_0, t_1) = \begin{cases} \int_{t_1}^{t_0} \left(\frac{dt}{a(t)} \right) & k = 0 \\ \sin \left(\int_{t_1}^{t_0} \left(\frac{dt}{a(t)} \right) \right) & k = 1 \\ \sinh \left(\int_{t_1}^{t_0} \left(\frac{dt}{a(t)} \right) \right) & k = -1 \end{cases} \quad (67)$$

Then we want to calculate the integral:

$$\int_{t_1}^{t_0} \left(\frac{dt}{a(t)} \right) \quad (68)$$

For a general universe, the Friedmann equation and Energy conservation equation gives Equation 45. We copy it here:

$$H^2 = H_0^2 \left(\Omega_\Lambda + \Omega_k \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^2 + \Omega_m \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^3 + \Omega_\gamma \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^4 \right) \quad (69)$$

Remark

Note that in this equation we set a time t_0 to define H_0, a_0 and Ω_i these constants. Here in the context of distance, we take t_0 to be the time when the light is emitted (note this conflicted with the previous convention where we take t_0 to be the time when the light is observed, and t_1 to be the time when the light is emitted).

We make a change of variable $x = \frac{a}{a_0}$, then we have:

$$\dot{x} = H_0 A(x)x, \quad A(x)^2 = (\Omega_\Lambda + \Omega_k x^{-2} + \Omega_m x^{-3} + \Omega_\gamma x^{-4}) \quad (70)$$

With these preparation we can calculate the integral:

$$\int_{t_1}^{t_0} \left(\frac{dt}{a(t)} \right) = \frac{1}{a_0 H_0} \int_{x_1}^{x_0} \left(\frac{dx}{A(x)x^2} \right) \quad x_0 = 1, x_1 = \frac{a(t_1)}{a_0} = \frac{1}{1+z} \quad (71)$$

Then the final formula for the luminosity distance is given by:

Corollary 3.6

Luminosity Distance to Redshift

The luminosity distance can be calculated as a function of redshift as:

$$d(z) = a_0(1+z) \frac{1}{\sqrt{-k}} \sinh \left(\frac{\sqrt{-k}}{a_0 H_0} \int_{\frac{1}{1+z}}^1 \left(\frac{dx}{A(x)x^2} \right) \right) \quad (72)$$

This is combining the three cases of k into one formula, for $k = 0$ we take the limit $k \rightarrow 0$ and use the fact that $\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \left(\frac{\sinh(x)}{x} \right) = 1$.

3.5.2 Parallax

Consider we have a source very far from the sun and we want to measure the distance between another star, which is much closer to the sun (though still very far from us). We can measure the angle between the source and the star at two different time (for example, at two different position of the earth in its orbit around the sun). This is called parallax.

See the diagram for illustration:

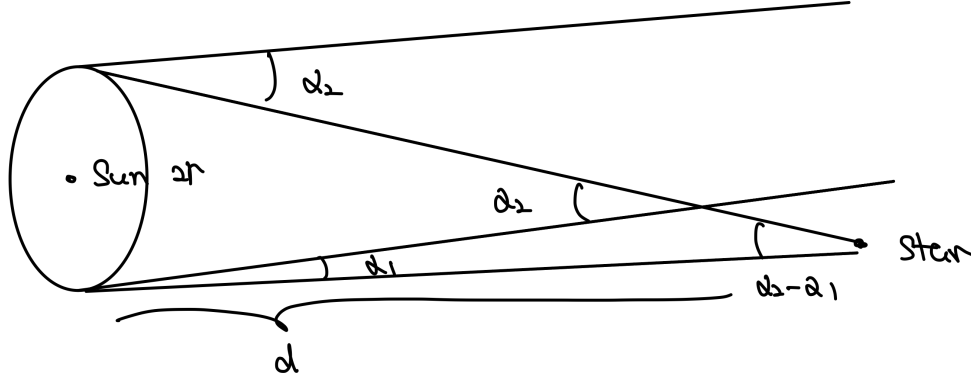


Figure 5: Parallax measurement.

The parallax is defined as:

Definition 3.7

Parallax

The parallax is defined as the angle between the source and the star at two different time.

$$\alpha_2 - \alpha_1 \quad (73)$$

A distance can be calculated from the parallax as:

$$d = \frac{2r}{\alpha_2 - \alpha_1} \quad (74)$$

where r is the distance between the sun and the earth.

4 Lecture 4: Thermal History of the Universe I: Equilibrium

4.1 Review on Euilibrium Statistical Mechanics

4.1.1 Occupation Number and Thermal Distribution Function

For a Equilibrium system, Bosons and Fermions have different occupational number:

Theorem 4.1

Occupation Number of Bosons and Fermions

For a system in equilibrium, the occupation number of bosons and fermions are given by:

$$n_B(E) = \frac{1}{e^{\frac{E-\mu}{T}} - 1}, \quad n_F(E) = \frac{1}{e^{\frac{E-\mu}{T}} + 1} \quad (75)$$

where E is the energy of the state, μ is the chemical potential and T is the temperature.

The thermal distribution function of the particles are given by $f(p)$, it is related to the occupation number and the number of dof of the particle:

Definition 4.2

Thermal Distribution Function

The thermal distribution function of the particle i is given by:

$$f_i(p) = \left(\frac{g_i}{(2\pi)^3} \right) n_i(E(p)) \quad E(p) = \sqrt{p^2 + m_i^2} \quad (76)$$

Remark

As a reminder of convention of statistical mechanics. the $(2\pi\hbar)^3$ or in the above formula $(2\pi)^3$ where we set $\hbar = 1$ is the density of phase space. and g_i is the number of degrees of freedom of the particle, for example, for a photon we have $g_i = 2$ because it has two polarization states.

For total number of particle, we need to integrate over the phase space $d^3x d^3p$, yet we leave the spacial part d^3x out because we are interested in the number density, which is the number of particle per unit volume. Thus we only integrate over the momentum space d^3p .

Integrating over $f_i(p)$ gives the **number density** of the particle and integrating with the weight of energy gives the **energy density** of the particle:

- **Number Density:**

$$N_i = \int f_i(p) d^3p \quad (77)$$

- **Energy Density:**

$$\rho_i = \int E(p) f_i(p) d^3p \quad (78)$$

4.1.2 Energy and Number Density in Relativistic Limit

The number density and energy density at equilibrium can be calculated explicitly. For particles in the **relativistic limit**, we means really high temperature::

$$T \gg m_i \Rightarrow T \sim E \sim |p| \quad (79)$$

and now we assume **zero chemical potential** we can calculate the number density and energy density as:

- **Energy Density:**

$$\rho_i = \begin{cases} \left(\frac{\pi^2}{30}\right)g_i T^4 & \text{Boson} \\ \frac{7}{8}\left(\frac{\pi^2}{20}\right)g_i T^4 & \text{Fermion} \end{cases} \quad (80)$$

- **Number Density:**

$$N_i = \begin{cases} \left(\frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2}\right)g_i T^3 & \text{Boson} \\ \frac{3}{4}\left(\frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2}\right)g_i T^3 & \text{Fermion} \end{cases} \quad (81)$$

We can also calculate the average energy of the particle in this limit:

$$\langle E \rangle = \frac{\rho_i}{N_i} \quad (82)$$

For the convenience of calculating energy density of system with multiple particle species, we can define the **effective number of species**:

$$g_* = \sum_{\text{boson}} g_i + \left(\frac{7}{8}\right) \sum_{\text{fermion}} g_i \quad (83)$$

and the energy density of the system can be calculated as:

$$\rho = \left(\frac{\pi^2}{30}\right)g_* T^4 \quad (84)$$

4.1.3 Entropy Density in Relativistic Limit

From the second law of thermodynamics, we have:

$$E = TS - PV + \mu N \quad (85)$$

we take the assumption that the chemical potential is zero, then we have:

$$s = \frac{S}{V} = \frac{\rho + P}{T} \quad (86)$$

where ρ is the energy density and P is the pressure of the system. For a relativistic particle remember we have Equation 16, we take $P = \frac{1}{3}\rho$ for relativistic particle, thus we have:

$$s = \frac{4}{3}\left(\frac{\rho}{T}\right) \quad (87)$$

4.1.4 Energy and Number Density in Non-Relativistic Limit

For non-relativistic limit, we means that:

$$m_i \gg T \Rightarrow E \sim m_i + \frac{p^2}{2m_i} \quad (88)$$

Note that here μ can be important. In this region the number density and energy density can be calculated as:

- **Number Density:**

$$N_i = g_i \left(\frac{m_i T}{2\pi} \right)^{\frac{3}{2}} \exp\left(\frac{\mu_i - m_i}{T} \right) \quad (89)$$

- **Energy Density:**

$$\rho_i = m_i N_i(T) + \frac{3}{2} N_i T \quad (90)$$

However, due to the fact that its a non-relativistic particle, the rest mass energy is much larger than the kinetic energy, thus we can approximate the energy density as:

$$\rho_i = m_i N_i \quad (91)$$

Moreover the pressure of the particle is given by:

$$P_i = g_i N_i T \ll \rho_i \quad (92)$$

Thus, we can see Equation 16 that the pressureless dust approximation is valid for non-relativistic particle.

4.2 Temperature Today

With these preparation of thermodynamics, we can calculate the temperature today. We first assume that the universe is:

- $k = 0, \Lambda = 0$ and dominated by relativistic particles that are in thermal equilibrium.

then the Friedmann equation gives Equation 42 :

$$H = \left(\frac{8\pi G}{3} \rho_{\text{rad}} \right)^{\frac{1}{2}} \quad (93)$$

And from the thermodynamics calculation we have Equation 84, we then can see the temperature dependency of the Hubble parameter:

$$H = \frac{T^2}{M_0} \quad M_0 = \sqrt{\frac{45}{4\pi^3 G g_*}} \quad (94)$$

where g_* is the effective number of species at the time.

For a radiation dominated universe, we have $a(t) \sim t^{\frac{1}{2}}$, or if we choose a time t_0 to define a_0 we have $a(t) = a_0 \left(\frac{t}{t_0} \right)^{\frac{1}{2}}$. Then:

$$H = \frac{\dot{a}}{a} = \frac{1}{2t} \quad (95)$$

Finally, we arrive at the relation between temperature and time:

$$\frac{T^2}{M_0} = \frac{1}{2t} \Rightarrow T = \sqrt{\frac{M_0}{2t}} \quad (96)$$

Now we can estimate with real numbers. for g_* we can plug in the standard model particles which gives $g_* \sim 100$. If we plug in the age of the universe, then the temperature turns out to be quite as the same of CMB.

The calculated temperature is not really the CMB, but a temperature that we assume the universe has if its always radiation dominant and in thermal equilibrium. However, in fact:

1. Today the universe is not radiation dominated.

2. The CMB temperature is the freeze-out temperature of the photon, which is the effective temperature after the photon decouples from the matter and stop interacting with it.

Yet its quite amazing that this really rough calculation can give us a quite sensible result.

Here we can also draw a useful relation between $a(t)$ and T , for a radiation dominated universe and roughly assuming the thermal equilibrium, we have:

$$\frac{a(t)}{a_0} = \left(\frac{t}{t_0} \right)^{\frac{1}{2}} = \left(\frac{T_0}{T} \right) \quad (97)$$

5 Lecture 5: Thermal History of the Universe II: Non-Equilibrium

The Universe is not always in thermal equilibrium, now we have to consider the non-equilibrium processes in the universe.

5.1 Free Particle Boltzmann Equation

5.1.1 A Convention Shift

For a non-equilibrium system, we need to consider the Boltzmann equation, which describes the evolution of the distribution function of particles in phase space. Here we use a different convention (as in the lecture note), we have:

$$n_{i \text{ old}}(p, t) = \frac{(2\pi)^3}{g_i} f_i(p, t) \rightarrow n_i(p, t) = (2\pi)^3 f_i(p, t) \quad (98)$$

Then the number density is:

$$N_i = \int \frac{d^3p}{(2\pi)^3} n_i(p, t) \quad (99)$$

and similarly for the energy density.

An important remark is that the distribution p we use the **physial momentum**, for detailed definition see next subsection.

5.1.2 Free Particle in an Expanding Universe

We first consider the free particle, in an expanding universe. The Lagrangian is given by:

$$\mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{2} m g_{ij}(\dot{x}^i \dot{x}^j) \quad (100)$$

here $\dot{x}$ is the derivative with respect to the coordinate time t . We now can explicitly define two momentums:

- **Physical Momentum:** $\mathcal{L} = \frac{p_p^2}{2m}$ this gives us: $p_p^i = m a(t) \dot{x}^i$.
- **Comoving Momentum:** $p_c^i = \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \dot{x}^i}$ this gives us: $p_c^i = m a(t)^2 \dot{x}^i$.

Then from the Euler-Lagrange equation, we can get the equation of motion of the particle, which is given by:

$$\frac{d}{dt} p_c^i = 0 \quad (101)$$

Remark

This can also be view given by the Noether's theorem of spacial translation symmetry.

Wethen can see that the comoving momentum is conserved, which means that the physical momentum is redshifted by the expansion of the universe:

$$p_p^i = \frac{p_c^i}{a(t)} = \frac{\text{constant}}{a(t)} \quad (102)$$

if we choose an “initial time” t_0 and define the physical momentum at that time as p_0 and $a(t_0) = a_0$, then we can write the physical momentum at any time as:

$$p_0^i = \frac{p_c^i}{a_0} = p_p^i \frac{a(t)}{a_0} \quad (103)$$

Thus given a time t , we want to measure the number of particle with physical momentum p , due to the fact that the comoving momentum is conserved, the number is equal to number of particle at t_0 with physical momentum $p \frac{a(t)}{a_0}$. Thus we have:

$$n_i(p, t) = n_i\left(p \frac{a(t)}{a_0}, t_0\right) \equiv n_{i0}\left(p \frac{a(t)}{a_0}\right) \quad (104)$$

Why we care about this form of distribution depends on some “initial distribution”? it is because particles in the universe, they first interact with each other when temperature is high and they are likely to stay in a thermal equilibrium distribution. However, when temperature lowers down, the interaction is not likely to happen, thus the particle will behave like a free particle and evolve.

This procedure ensures us the knowledge of the distribution at the initial time t_0 (as a thermal equilibrium distribution) and we can use the above formula to see how the distribution evolves with time.

See the diagram for illustration:

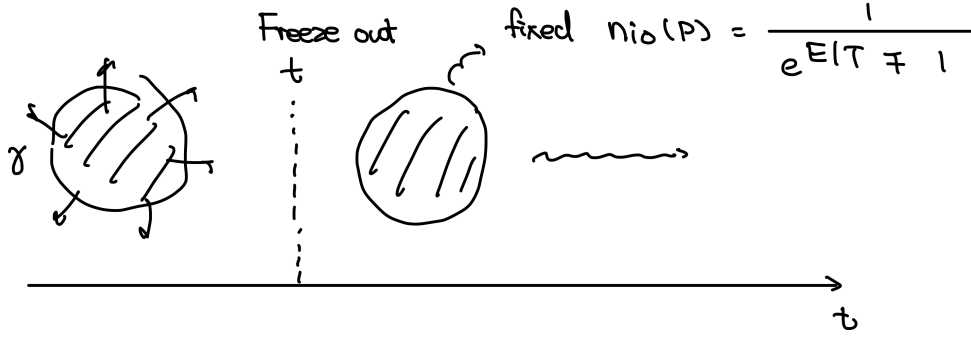


Figure 6: The process of freeze-out.

5.1.3 Effective Temperature

Now consider the process described in above remark. Initially the particle is in thermal equilibrium, thus we have a thermal distribution at the initial time t_0 :

$$n_{i0}(p) = g_i \frac{1}{\exp\left(\frac{E(p) - \mu_i}{T_0}\right) \pm 1} \quad (105)$$

Then the interaction turns off and the particle evolves as a free particle, thus we have:

$$n_i(p, t) = n_{i0}\left(p \frac{a(t)}{a_0}\right) = g_i \frac{1}{\exp\left(\frac{E\left(p \frac{a(t)}{a_0}\right) - \mu_i}{T_0}\right) \pm 1} \quad (106)$$

In some cases, we can define an **effective temperature** and make all the time dependence of this distribution into the effective temperature. Thus we can use this effective temperature and a equilibrium distribution to describe the distribution of the particle at any time.

Remark

The effective temperature is not really a temperature for the particle is free and not in thermal equilibrium and we don't have a notion of temperature.

Yet it is a measurable quantity, for we can measure the energy distribution of the particle and fit it with a thermal distribution, then we can get the effective temperature from experiment.

- **Massless Particle**

For massless particle, the energy is given by $E(p) = p$, if we neglect the chemical potential, we have:

$$n_i(p, t) = g_i \frac{1}{\exp\left(\frac{pa(t)}{a_0 T_0}\right) \pm 1} \quad (107)$$

Then we define the effective temperature as:

Definition 5.1

Effective Temperature for Massless Particle

The effective temperature for a massless particle is given by:

$$T_{\text{eff}}(t) = T_0 \frac{a_0}{a(t)} \quad (108)$$

Then the distribution of the particle can be written as:

$$n_i(p, t) = g_i \frac{1}{\exp\left(\frac{p}{T_{\text{eff}}(t)}\right) \pm 1} \quad (109)$$

In fact in cosmology, we often use the mixed use the effective temperature of relativistic particle and the assumed equilibrium temperature of radiation dominant universe. A justification may be that they both evolve as:

$$T_{\text{eff}}(t) = T_0 \frac{a_0}{a(t)} \quad \text{and} \quad T(t) = T_0 \frac{a_0}{a(t)} \quad (110)$$

It is invalid rigorously I know, yet it amazingly works for many cases. For example, before we calculate the temperature of the universe as a thermal equilibrium relativistic system and the temperature turns out to be quite as the same of CMB which is the effective temperature of the photons in the universe.

However, sometimes it can't give a correct result and we need some further justifications. Eg. the difference between the effective temperature of neutrinos and the CMB temperature. This happens due to some extra processes happening in the universe that makes the evolution of temperature not that simple.

- **Massive Particle**

See section 2.5 of the book [1] for more details.

5.1.4 Free Particle Boltzmann Equation

Then we can derive the Boltzmann equation for a free particle in an expanding universe. We have:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} n_i(p, t) = \frac{d}{dt} n_{0i} \left(p \frac{a(t)}{a_0} \right) = (n'_{0i}) \times \left(p \frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a_0} \right) \quad (111)$$

and

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial p} n_i(p, t) = n'_{0i} \times \left(\frac{a(t)}{a_0} \right) \quad (112)$$

we combine the two equations together, we can get:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} n_i(p, t) - \left(\frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a(t)} p \right) \frac{\partial}{\partial p} n_i(p, t) = 0 \quad (113)$$

Then we have the Boltzmann equation for a free particle in an expanding universe:

Theorem 5.2

Free Particle Boltzmann Equation

The Boltzmann equation for a free particle in an expanding universe is given by:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} n_i(p, t) - (Hp) \frac{\partial}{\partial p} n_i(p, t) = 0 \quad (114)$$

where $H = \frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a(t)}$ is the Hubble parameter.

We can see that a “free particle” in an expanding universe is not really free, it is affected by the expansion of the universe, which causes the redshift of the physical momentum.

We then can integrate the Boltzmann equation over the momentum space, we can get the equation for the number density:

$$\dot{N}_i(t) + 3H(t)N_i(t) = 0 \quad (115)$$

Remark

Remember the convention is changed and we integrate with $(d^3p)/(2\pi)^3$ measure. We'd mainly prefer using number density instead of distribution function as the variable.

5.2 Interacting Particle Boltzmann Equation

5.2.1 Interacting Particle Boltzmann Equation

Then we consider a particles with interactions. The generalization is done by adding a collision term I_{col} to the Boltzmann equation:

Theorem 5.3

Interacting Particle Boltzmann Equation

The Boltzmann equation for an interacting particle in an expanding universe is given by:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} n_i(p, t) - (Hp) \frac{\partial}{\partial p} n_i(p, t) = I_{\text{col}} \quad (116)$$

where I_{col} is the collision term, which describes the interactions of the particle with other particles.

If we focus on **2 to 2 scattering procedure**, the collision term can be written in terms of the scattering amplitude of the procedure, which is given by:

$$I_{\text{col}} = -\frac{1}{2E_p} \int \frac{d^3 q_1}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{d^3 q_2}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{d^3 q_3}{(2\pi)^3} (2\pi)^4 \delta^{(4)}(p + q_1 - q_2 - q_3) |\mathcal{M}|^2 \times [n(p)n(q_1)(1 \pm n(q_2))(1 \pm n(q_3)) - n(q_3)n(q_2)(1 \pm n(p))(1 \pm n(q_1))] \quad (117)$$

This equation is quite impossible to solve analytically, yet we have the technique of **Relaxation Time Approximation**, which we expand around the equilibrium distribution $n_i^{\text{eq}}(p)$.

5.2.2 Relaxation Time Approximation

We consider at $H = 0$ we have the equilibrium distribution $n_i^{\text{eq}}(p)$, we can prove that:

$$I_{\text{col}}(n_i^{\text{eq}}(p)) = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{d}{dt} n_i^{\text{eq}}(p) = 0 \quad (118)$$

where n_i^{eq} is exactly the Bose-Einstein distribution or the Fermi-Dirac distribution.

- This means that in an interaction dominated system, all particles tend to have the equilibrium distribution, which is given by the Bose-Einstein distribution or the Fermi-Dirac distribution.

Then we can expand the actual distribution around the equilibrium distribution, in this limit:

$$I_{\text{col}}(n_i) = I_{\text{col}}(n_i^{\text{eq}} + \delta n_i) = I_{\text{col}}(n_i^{\text{eq}}) + \left(\frac{\delta I_{\text{col}}}{\delta n_i} \right) \delta n_i + \dots = -\Gamma \times (n_i - n_i^{\text{eq}}) \quad (119)$$

Thus the Boltzmann equation becomes:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} n_i(p, t) - (Hp) \frac{\partial}{\partial p} n_i(p, t) = -\Gamma \times (n_i - n_i^{\text{eq}}) \quad (120)$$

or if we integrate over the momentum space, we can get the equation for the number density:

Theorem 5.4

Relaxation Time Approximation Boltzmann Equation

The Boltzmann equation for an interacting particle in an expanding universe in the relaxation time approximation is given by:

$$\dot{N}_i(t) + 3H(t)N_i(t) = -\Gamma \times (N_i(t) - N_i^{\text{eq}}) \quad (121)$$

Now we talk more about Γ . It has a physical meaning as the **rate of reaction**:

$$\Gamma = \frac{1}{\tau} = \langle \lambda/v \rangle^{-1} \quad (122)$$

where τ is the **mean free time** of the collision and λ is the **mean free path** of the collision and v is the **relative velocity** of the particle. The mean free path is related to the **cross section** of the collision by:

$$\lambda = \frac{1}{\sigma N} \quad (123)$$

where σ is the cross section of the collision and N is the number density of the particle. A commonly used formula for Γ is given by:

$$\Gamma = \langle N v \sigma \rangle \quad (124)$$

Thus we can see that Γ is not time independent, it depends on the number density of the particle and the velocity of particle, which can change with time.

5.3 Freeze-in and Freeze-out

With this Boltzmann equation, we can now understand the process of **freeze-in** and **freeze-out** of particles in the early universe. Note that from the Boltzmann equation, the number of particles changes due to two effects:

- **Expansion of the universe:** which is given by the term $3H(t)N_i(t)$.
- **Interactions of the particle:** which is given by the term $-\Gamma \times (N_i(t) - N_i^{\text{eq}})$.

Both terms are given by a rate Γ and H . We can find that both rates are **Temperature Dependent**:

- Γ depends on v the relative velocity of the particle, which is related to the temperature of the universe.
- H depends on time as universe expands, which is also related to the temperature of the universe Equation 96.

Thus, as the universe cools down, different terms will dominate at different temperature, which gives us the process of freeze-in and freeze-out.

5.3.1 Asymptotic Behavior of the Boltzmann Equation

We discuss first the asymptotic solution of the Boltzmann equation. We have two limits:

- $\Gamma(T) \gg H(T)$: in this limit, the interaction term dominates, thus we have

$$N_i(t) \approx N_i^{\text{eq}} \quad (125)$$

which means that the particle is in thermal equilibrium with the universe.

- $\Gamma(T) \ll H(T)$: in this limit, the expansion term dominates, Boltzmann equation becomes:

$$\frac{d}{dt}(a^3 N_i) = 0 \quad (126)$$

Thus, the number density deviate from the equilibrium value, and we have:

$$N(T) \approx N^{\text{eq}}(T_*) \left(\frac{a(T_*)}{a(T)} \right)^3 \quad (127)$$

where T_* is the temperature at which $\Gamma(T_*) \approx H(T_*)$. This means the time we should not only consider the expansion of the universe, but also the interaction of the particle.

The critical temperature T_* is called the **freeze-out/in temperature** of the particle, depends on $\frac{\Gamma}{H}$ is decreasing or increasing with temperature, we can have freeze-out or freeze-in process.

5.4 Electron-Positron Gas Freeze-out

We finally can come to a concrete example of the freeze-out process, which is the freeze-out of the electron-positron gas in the early universe. We consider the following scattering process:

$$e^+ e^- \leftrightarrow \gamma \gamma \quad (128)$$

With this process occurring we assume that the universe is **radiation dominant !!**

5.4.1 Scattering Cross Section and Rate of Reaction

The scattering cross section of this process is given by:

$$\sigma = \begin{cases} \frac{1}{2v} \pi r_e^2 & v \ll 1 \\ \frac{m_e^2}{E^2} \pi r_e^2 \left(\log \left(\frac{(2E)^2}{m_e^2} \right) - 1 \right) & v \approx 1 \end{cases} \quad (129)$$

where r_e is $\frac{\alpha}{m_e}$, E is the center of mass energy of the collision, and v is the relative velocity of the particle.

This cross section is depending on the velocity of the particle, which is related to the temperature of the universe. In both limits we can calculate the rate of reaction Γ :

- **Relativistic Limit:** $T \geq m_e$ in this limit we take:

$$\sigma \approx \frac{m_e^2}{E^2} \pi r_e^2 \left(\log \left(\frac{(2E)^2}{m_e^2} \right) - 1 \right) \approx \frac{\alpha^2}{T^2} \quad (130)$$

Remark

In this approximation we take $E \approx T$ for relativistic particle and we assume the logarithm term is order of 1.

and remember that the number density of relativistic particle for equilibrium case is given by:

$$N_i^{\text{eq}} = \frac{3}{4} \left(\frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} \right) g_i T^3 \quad (131)$$

Thus we have:

$$\Gamma = \langle N v \sigma \rangle \sim \alpha^2 T \quad (132)$$

- **Non-Relativistic Limit:** $T \leq m_e$ in this limit we take:

$$\sigma \approx \frac{1}{2v} \pi r_e^2 \quad (133)$$

and remember that the number density of non-relativistic particle for equilibrium case is given by:

$$N_i^{\text{eq}} = g_i \left(\frac{m_i T}{2\pi} \right)^{\frac{3}{2}} \exp \left(\frac{\mu_i - m_i}{T} \right) \quad (134)$$

Thus we have:

$$\Gamma = \langle N v \sigma \rangle \sim r_e^2 (T m_e)^{\frac{3}{2}} \exp \left(\frac{-m_e}{T} \right) \quad (135)$$

Remark

We here take the chemical potential μ_i to be zero, which is a good approximation in the radiation dominant universe.

5.4.2 Freeze-in/out Temperature

We list out the rate of reaction and the Hubble parameter:

$$\Gamma = \begin{cases} \sim \alpha^2 T & T \geq m_e \\ \sim r_e^2 (T m_e)^{\frac{3}{2}} \exp \left(\frac{-m_e}{T} \right) & T \leq m_e \end{cases} \quad (136)$$

while the Hubble parameter (in a radiation dominant univers) is given by Equation 94, we copy it here:

$$H = \frac{T^2}{M_0} \quad (137)$$

Remark

We here are assuming that the universe happening all those processes is radiation dominant, which is a good approximation for the early universe. Thus, we can neglect the chemical potential of the particle, and use this Hubble parameter to calculate the freeze-out/in temperature.

We draw the plot of Γ and H as a function of temperature:

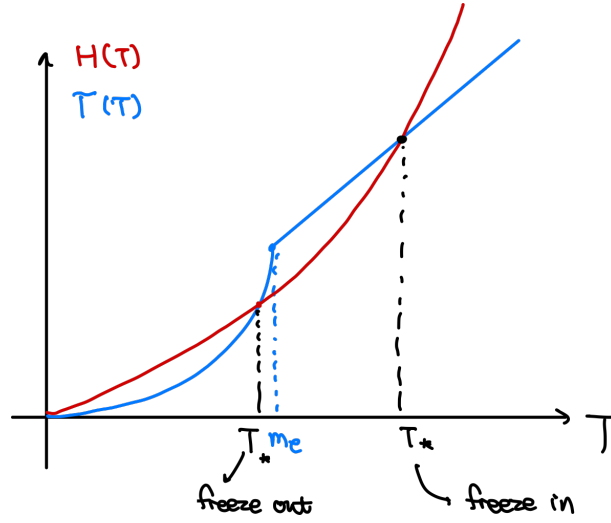


Figure 7: The plot of the rate of reaction Γ and the Hubble parameter H as a function of temperature. The intersection point of the two curves gives us the freeze-out/in temperature of the particle.

we can calculate the freeze-out/in temperature by solving the equation $\Gamma(T_*) = H(T_*)$:

- **freeze in** : this is easy to solve, we have:

$$T_{\text{in}} \sim \alpha^2 M_0 = 10^{14} \text{ GeV} \quad (138)$$

- **freeze out**: this is hard to solve, we can only get an approximate solution by taking the logarithm of the equation, we have:

$$r_e^2 (T m_e)^{\frac{3}{2}} \exp\left(\frac{-m_e}{T}\right) \sim \frac{T^2}{M_0} \quad (139)$$

which gives us:

$$T_{\text{out}} \sim \frac{m_e}{40} = 10 \text{ keV} \quad (140)$$

5.4.3 Physical Interpretation

In this process, in a radiation dominant universe, we assume that **the photon is in thermal equilibrium with the universe**, thus we have $N_\gamma \sim a^{-3}$ only changes due to the expansion of the universe. Then we can use $\frac{N_e}{N_\gamma}$ to represent the number of electrons.

- When $m_e < T < T_{\text{in}}$ the electrons are in thermal equilibrium due to the fact that $\Gamma \gg H$, while we can approximate it as a relativistic particle. Due to the fact that Equation 131, we have:

$$\frac{N_e}{N_\gamma} \sim \frac{g_e}{g_\gamma} \sim 1 \quad (141)$$

- When $T_{\text{out}} < T < m_e$ the electrons are not in thermal equilibrium due to the fact that $\Gamma \ll H$, while we can approximate it as a non-relativistic particle. Due to the fact that the number density of non-relativistic particle is given by Equation 134.

The electron number density shinks exponentially as the universe cools down.

- When $T < T_{\text{out}}$ the scatter is minor and the number of electrons is only affected by the expansion of the universe, thus now we have the number density of electrons given by as $N_e \sim N_* a^{-3}$. where N_* is the number density of electrons at the freeze-out temperature T_{out} .

If we plot the number density of electrons as a function of temperature, we can see that the number density of electrons shinks exponentially as the universe cools down as $T < m_e$, and finally freezes out at T_{out} :

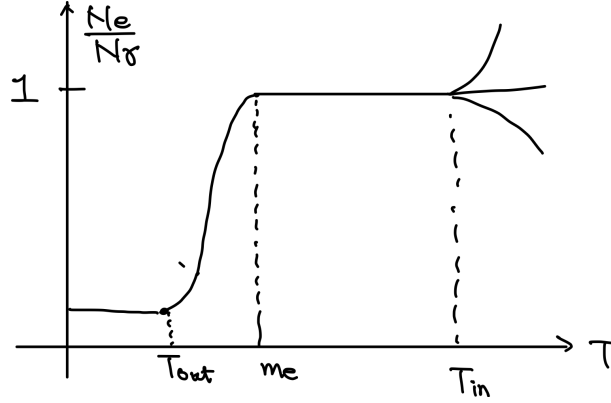


Figure 8: The plot of the number density of electrons as a function of temperature.

An important remark is that the plot is independent of the initial number density and things happening at $T > T_{\text{in}}$.

6 Lecture 6: Recombination and Neutrino Freeze Out

Now we start to focus on more concrete process happened in the universe. Now I'll list out a timeline of the process happened in the universe, which is shown in the following figure:

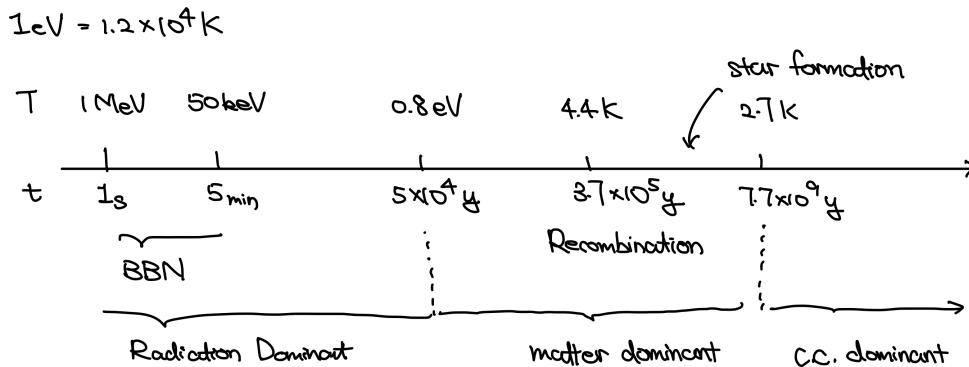


Figure 9: Timeline of the thermal history of the universe.

This lecture we will focus on the process of recombination and neutrino freeze out which happens long before, even before the BBN process.

Note that the freeze out of electrons and positrons we discussed last lecture happens right after BBN.

6.1 Recombination

This is the process when the CMB is emitted. Before the recombination, the universe is filled with plasma, which is opaque to photons, with the main reaction happening as:



Yet as the universe expands and cools down, the reaction will be more difficult to happen when the temperature drops and energy is lower than the binding energy of the hydrogen atom. Then the universe becomes transparent to photons, and photons are decoupled from matter, and free to propagate in the universe.

The slice when the last scattering happens is called the last scattering surface, which is the source of the CMB we observed today.

6.1.1 Saha Equation

We now focus on the process of recombination, which protons and electrons combine to form neutral hydrogen atoms. In order to calculate the recombination temperature, we need to get the number density of electrons. This can be done with the help of the Saha equation.

There exists a simple equation to describe the process of:



when the elements are in thermal equilibrium, which is called the Saha equation:

Theorem 6.1

The Saha Equation

The Saha equation describes the ionization state of a gas in thermal equilibrium, relating the number densities of ions and electrons to the temperature and ionization energy. It is given by:

$$\frac{N_e N_p}{N_H} = \left(\frac{m_e T}{2\pi} \right)^{\frac{3}{2}} \exp\left(-\frac{I}{T}\right) \quad (144)$$

where N_i is the number density of species i , m_e is the electron mass, T is the temperature, and $I = m_e + m_p - m_H$ is the ionization energy of hydrogen.

All elements other than photons can be view as thermal equilibrium non-relativistic particles, and the equilibrium number density can be calculated as Equation 89. we copy it here for convenience:

$$N_i = g_i \left(\frac{m_i T}{2\pi} \right)^{\frac{3}{2}} \exp\left(\frac{\mu_i - m_i}{T}\right) \quad (145)$$

the polarization degree of freedom for proton and electron are both 2, and for hydrogen atom is 4, thus we have $g_e = g_p = 2$ and $g_H = 4$. Moreover, in chemical equilibrium the chemical potential of the reaction is zero, thus we have

$$\mu_e + \mu_p = \mu_H \quad (146)$$

With these preparation, we can derive the Saha equation as above.

Remark

Note that here we have assumed that the hydrogen mass is nearly the mass of proton.

6.1.2 Recombination Temperature

To calculate the recombination temperature, generally we have to consider a complicated scattering between photons and protons and electrons. However, to make it simple, we can only consider the process that photon can scatter with electrons, and ignore the scattering between photons and protons, which is a good approximation since the cross section of photon-electron scattering is much larger than that of photon-proton scattering.

Then we only have to focus on the **Thompson scattering** process, which is the scattering between photons and electrons:

$$\gamma + e^- \rightarrow \gamma + e^- \quad (147)$$

To do the calculation, we need some facts and assumptions:

- Assume the universe is neutral, and positrons are mostly annihilated after the freeze out of electrons and positrons, thus we have $N_e = N_p$.
- Fact: from the derivation of BBN, we can prove that the baryon to photon ratio is $\eta = N_b/N_\gamma = 6 \times 10^{-10}$, where N_b is the number density of baryons, and N_γ is the number density of photons.
- Fact: the fraction of protons in baryons is about 0.75, thus we have $N_p = 0.75N_b$.
- Assume that at the temperature of interest most protons have combined with electrons to form hydrogen atoms, thus we have $N_H = N_{p \text{ original}}$.

With these assumptions, we now can see that the number density of electrons can be expressed through Saha equation assuming $N_e = N_p$ as:

$$N_e = N_H^{1/2} \left(\frac{m_e T}{2\pi} \right)^{3/4} \exp\left(-\frac{I}{2T}\right) \quad (148)$$

While N_H can be expressed through the baryon to photon ratio as:

$$N_H = N_{p \text{ orig}} = 0.75 N_b = 0.75 \eta N_\gamma = 0.75 \eta \left(2 \frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} \right) T^3 \quad (149)$$

In the final equation we use the equilibrium number density of photons, given by Equation 81. With the number density of electrons, we can calculate the Γ of Thompson scattering as:

$$\Gamma = \langle \sigma_{\gamma e} N_e v \rangle \quad (150)$$

the cross section of Thompson scattering is given by:

$$\sigma_{\gamma e} = \frac{8\pi\alpha^2}{3m_e^2} \quad (151)$$

The recombination happens when the scattering effect is as the same order as the expansion effect (freeze out), thus we have the condition:

$$H = \Gamma \Rightarrow B \frac{T^{9/4}}{m_e^{5/4}} e^{-I/2T} = \frac{T^2}{M_0} \quad (152)$$

where B is a constant given by:

$$B = \frac{8\pi\alpha^2}{3} \eta^{1/2} \left(\frac{2\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} \right)^{1/2} \left(\frac{1}{2\pi} \right)^{3/4} \quad (153)$$

Note that here we take $v = 1$, which is the speed of light, since the photons is involved.

We finally get the recombination temperature as:

$$T_{\text{dec}} = 0.25 \text{ eV} \sim 3000 \text{ K} \quad (154)$$

6.1.3 CMB Temperature

This temperature is the temperature of the photons at the time of recombination, and then afterwards the photons are decoupled from matter and free to propagate in the universe, which becomes the CMB. As the CMB propagates it can be described as free particles and has a effective temperature, which is the CMB temperature.

Today, the CMB temperature is measured to be:

$$T_{\text{CMB}} = T_{\gamma,0} = 2.725 \text{ K} \quad (155)$$

By definition of effective temperature Section 5.1.3, we have the following relation:

$$T_{\gamma,0} = T_{\text{dec}} \left(\frac{a_{\text{dec}}}{a_0} \right) \quad (156)$$

One can calculate the ratio between this temperature at recombination and the temperature of CMB today, which gives us the redshift of the recombination. remember Equation 97, we have:

$$z_{\text{rec}} \sim \frac{a_0}{a_{\text{dec}}} = \frac{T_{\text{dec}}}{T_{\text{CMB}}} \sim 1100 \quad (157)$$

which is quite at the same order as the redshift of matter-radiation equality, which is given by $z_{\text{eq}} \sim 3000$. This means that the recombination happens quite close to the matter-radiation equality.

Remark

By definition, the redshift should be $z = a_0/a - 1$, we just ignore the -1 since the redshift is quite large.

6.2 Neutrino Freeze Out

Now we focus on another process happend before recombination, which is the neutrino freeze out. Neutrinos interacts with electrons:

$$\nu + e^- \rightarrow \nu + e^- \quad (158)$$

And when the temperature drops, the interaction will be more difficult to happen, it will be less dominant than the expansion, and eventually the neutrinos will freeze out and decouple from the matter.

Yet this interaction is much weaker than the Thompson scattering. Thus, it is expected to stop happening before the recombination happens. Lets now calculate the freeze out temperature of neutrinos.

6.2.1 Freeze Out Temperature of Neutrinos

The cross section of the neutrino-electron scattering is given by:

$$\langle \sigma_w v \rangle \sim G_F^2 E^2 \quad G_F = g^2 / M_w^2 \sim 10^{-5} \text{GeV}^{-2} \quad (159)$$

Remark

Note we assume that the neutrinos are massless, relativistic particles

Then we can calculate the Γ of neutrino-electron scattering as:

$$\Gamma = \langle \sigma_w v N_\nu \rangle \sim G_F^2 T^2 T^3 \quad (160)$$

Remark

Due to the fact we still view neutrinos as relativistic particles, we can calculate the energy of neutrinos as $E \sim T$, so we have T^2 .

Moreover, the number density of neutrinos can be calculated from the equilibrium number density of relativistic particles, which is given by Equation 81, thus we have $N_\nu \sim T^3$.

With this data calculated, we can calculate the freeze out temperature of neutrinos by comparing the scattering effect with the expansion effect:

$$\Gamma = H \quad \Rightarrow \quad G_F^2 T^5 = \frac{T^2}{M_0} \quad (161)$$

This gives us the freeze out temperature of neutrinos as:

$$T_*^\nu = (G_F^2 M_0)^{-1/3} \sim 2 \text{ MeV} \quad (162)$$

6.2.2 Neutrino and Photon Effective Temperature Ratio

After freeze out, the particle is not interacting with others, thus its distribution evolves as a free particle. This means that we can use the effective temperature to describe the distribution

of the particle, see Section 5.1.3 the definition of effective temperature for massless particles. By definition:

$$T_{\nu,0} = T_{\nu*} \left(\frac{a_*}{a_0} \right) \quad (163)$$

where $T_{\nu,0}$ is the effective temperature of neutrinos today, $T_{\nu*}$ is the freeze out temperature of neutrinos, a_* is the scale factor at the freeze out time, and a_0 is the scale factor today.

As I have claimed in former remarks, we often roughly assume that the effective temperature is the same as the assumed equilibrium (of course its not) temperature of the universe.

$$T_{\nu,0} \sim T_{\gamma,0} (\text{aka } T_{\text{CMB}}) \sim T_0 \quad (164)$$

Yet here we meet the first example that this approximation is not good.

The effective temperature of neutrino is not the same as the CMB temperature experimentally:

$$T_{\nu,0} \neq T_{\text{CMB}} \quad (165)$$

This is due to the effect that after the neutrino freeze out, the photons are still interacting with electrons and by then positrons and electrons annihilate each other, which gives out energy to photons and heat the photon up. Here is a time line of the process:

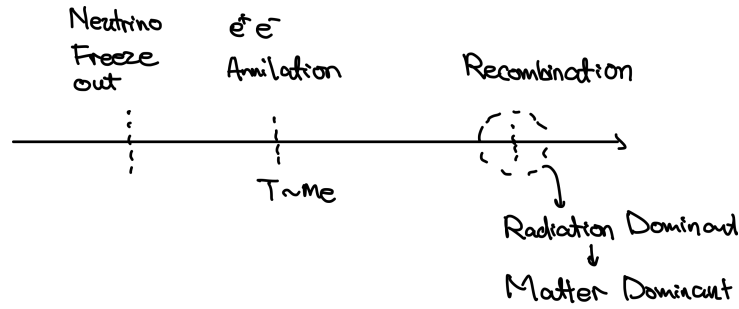


Figure 10: Timeline of the neutrino freeze out and recombination process.

We can calculate the ratio using the conservation of entropy. We think that the universe is a closed system, there's nothing "outside" the universe. Thus, the total entropy of the universe is conserved.

We further assume that the universe is radiation dominated (as we always did) and the entropy density of relativistic particle is given by Equation 87, then the total entropy of the universe is given by:

$$S = sV \sim g_* T^3 a^3 = \text{constant} \quad (166)$$

Remark

Here we have a a^3 due to the fact that the volume of the universe is given by $V \sim a^3$.

Then we consider right after the neutrinos freeze out, the interacting particles we assume only includes electrons, positrons and photons forming a plasma, and the neutrinos are already decoupled from the plasma. Thus the total entropy of the universe is given by:

$$S \sim (g_\gamma + g_{e^+e^-}) (T_*)^3 a_*^3 \quad g_{*\gamma} = 2, \quad g_{*e^+e^-} = \frac{7}{8}(2 + 2) \quad (167)$$

Then neutrino effective temperature goes like $T \sim \frac{1}{a}$, thus we have:

$$(T_{\nu*})a_* \sim T_{\nu,0}a_0 \quad (168)$$

Then some time later the positrons and electrons annihilate each other, the entropy of the universe is given by:

$$S \sim g_{*\gamma} T^3 a^3 \quad (169)$$

And remeber that during all these process the electron photon plasma is evolving as a relativistic equilibrium system and the temperature goes like $T \sim \frac{1}{a}$. Then the photon freeze out the effective temperature still goes like $T \sim \frac{1}{a}$. Thus we have:

$$Ta \sim T_{\gamma,0}a_0 \quad (170)$$

With all these ingrediants, we can calculate the ratio between the neutrino effective temperature and the photon effective temperature as:

$$\frac{T_{\nu,0}}{T_{\gamma,0}} = \left(\frac{g_\gamma + g_{e^+e^-}}{g_\gamma} \right)^{1/3} = \left(\frac{11}{4} \right)^{1/3} = 1.401 \quad (171)$$

From this equation we can get the effective temperature of neutrinos today from the CMB temperature:

$$T_{\nu,0} = \left(\frac{11}{4} \right)^{1/3} T_{\text{CMB}} \sim 2 \text{ K} \quad (172)$$

6.2.3 Cosmological Bound on Neutrino Mass

We first calculate the number density of neutrinos today, which is given by the equilibrium number density of relativistic particles Equation 81:

$$N_{\nu,0} = \left(\frac{3}{4} \right) g_\nu \left(\frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} \right) T_{\nu,0}^3 \quad (173)$$

There are different spicies of neutrinos, and due to the fact they interact with electrons in the same style we take this number density to be true to all spicies of neutrinos. Due to the relation between the photon effective temperature and the neutrino effective temperature, we can express the number density of neutrinos today through the photon number density today, which is given by:

$$N_{\nu,0} = \frac{3}{22} N_{\gamma,0} \quad (174)$$

In all above calculations we take the neutrinos to be massless particles, however, in reality from the neutrino oscillation experiments we know one neutrino is massless and others may have mass.

We want to use this number density to bound the mass of neutrinos. To do this, we know in fact the energy density of different spicies of particles are measureable, and for mass particles we have data;

$$\Omega_M < 0.4 \quad (175)$$

There is a bound that:

- Neutrino can not take up all matter in the universe

Mathematically, we have:

$$\Omega_\nu = \frac{\rho_{\nu,0}}{\rho_c} < \Omega_M \sim 0.4 \quad (176)$$

As non-relativistic particles, the energy density of massive neutrinos can be:

$$\rho_{\nu,0} = \sum_i m_{\nu,i} N_{\nu,0} = \sum_i m_{\nu,i} \left(\frac{3}{22} \right) N_{\gamma,0} \quad (177)$$

Eventually, we can get the bound on the mass of neutrinos as:

$$\sum_i m_{\nu,i} \leq 10 \text{ eV} \quad (178)$$

Remark

There are modern cosmological data that can give us a much stronger bound on the neutrino mass, which is given by:

$$\sum_i m_{\nu,i} \leq 0.2 \text{ eV} \quad (179)$$

7 Lecture 7: Big Bang Nucleosynthesis

This is the process before the freeze out discussed in the previous lectures. During BBN the protons and neutrons combine into light nuclei, such as deuterium, helium-3, helium-4 and lithium-7.

As a result of BBN, we have the two unexplained facts we used in recombination calculation of number density of hydrogen in recombination:

- The abundance of protons are of order of 75% and the abundance of helium-4 is of order of 25% and others are negligible.
- The baryon to photon ratio η
- ...

Now let's have a look at what happened during BBN.

7.1 Neutron to Proton Ratio at the Beginning of BBN

7.1.1 Generation of Neutrons

At the beginning of BBN, the neutrons are produced and destroyed by the weak interaction process:

$$p + e^- \leftrightarrow n + \nu_e \quad (180)$$

protons and electrons can combine to produce neutrons and electron neutrinos.

Remark

According to the time line, in fact neutrinos are already freeze out. However, freeze out doesn't really mean to decouple, it's just the interaction rate is smaller than the Hubble expansion rate, but it doesn't mean that there is no interaction at all.

One can calculate the freeze out temperature of the above process:

$$T^* \sim T_\nu^* \sim 2 \text{ MeV} \quad (181)$$

Thus it happens quite the same time as neutrino freeze out. A more precise calculation gives the freeze out temperature of the above process to be around:

$$T^* \sim 0.8 \text{ MeV} \quad (182)$$

which is slightly after the neutrino freeze out.

7.1.2 Saha Equation

Then we calculate the number density. Remember in recombination we calculate the number density of electrons using Saha equation. Here we will use the same method to calculate the number density of neutrons and protons.

Remember the number density of massive particles:

$$N_A = g_A \left(\frac{m_A T}{2\pi} \right)^{3/2} e^{(\mu_A - m_A)/T}, \quad (183)$$

and we assume that equilibrium holds, which means that the chemical potential of the above process should satisfy:

$$\mu_p + \mu_e = \mu_n + \mu_{\nu_e} \quad (184)$$

If we approximate the mass of protons and neutrons to be the same, then we have:

$$\frac{N_n}{N_p} = \exp\left(-\frac{m_n - m_p}{T} + \frac{\mu_e - \mu_{\nu_e}}{T}\right) \quad (185)$$

note here we use $\mu_n - \mu_p = \mu_e - \mu_{\nu_e}$ which is from the chemical potential relation. We already know that $m_n - m_p \sim 1.3 \text{ MeV}$. We now try to argue that: μ_{ν_e}/T and μ_e/T are negligible.

7.1.3 Negligible Chemical Potential

There is a basic result in thermodynamics that the difference of number density between particle and antiparticle is given by:

Theorem 7.1

Particle-Antiparticle Asymmetry

The difference of number density between particle and antiparticle at $T \gg m, \mu$ is given by:

$$\Delta N_i = \begin{cases} \mu T^3/6 & \text{fermion} \\ \mu T^3/3 & \text{boson} \end{cases} \quad (186)$$

The proof is that we assume the Boltzmann distribution and take a limit. Then we use the fact that the chemical potential of antiparticle is the negative of the chemical potential of particle, which means that $\mu_{(i)} = -\mu_i$.

With this result, we can see that:

$$\frac{\mu_e}{T} = 6 \frac{\Delta N_e}{T^3} \quad (187)$$

if we assume the universe is charge neutral, then we have $\Delta N_e = N_p$, and we know that:

$$N_p \sim \eta N_\gamma \sim \eta T^3 \quad (188)$$

Thus we see:

$$\frac{\mu_e}{T} \sim 6\eta \ll 1 \quad (189)$$

We here just **assume** that the chemical potential of neutrinos is also negligible.

7.1.4 Neutron to Proton Ratio

With above preparation, we can see that from the Saha equation, we have:

$$\frac{N_n}{N_p} = \exp\left(-\frac{m_n - m_p}{T}\right) \quad (190)$$

We plug in the freeze out temperature $T^* \sim 0.8 \text{ MeV}$ and the mass difference $m_n - m_p \sim 1.3 \text{ MeV}$, we can get the neutron to proton ratio at the beginning of BBN:

$$\frac{N_n}{N_p} \sim \frac{1}{5} \quad (191)$$

Remark

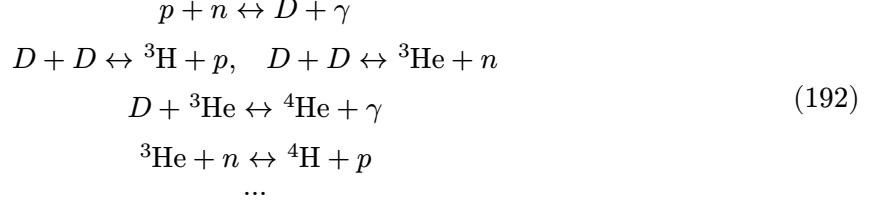
There is another effect that we haven't considered, which is the neutron decay. However, one can see that the above process happened quite fast $\sim 1s$ which is much smaller than the neutron decay time $\sim 880s$, thus we can ignore the effect of neutron decay at the beginning of BBN.

7.2 Nuclear Reaction

After we have neutrons and protons fixed, they can combine into light nuclei.

7.2.1 General Picture

Here is a general picture of the chain of nuclear reaction during BBN:



The reaction happens so on and so on. One can naively think that the neuclei with the largest binding energy per nucleon should be the most abundant, for it takes more energy to break every nucleon out of the nucleus. The binding energy is given by:

$$I_A = Zm_p + (A - Z)m_n - m_A \tag{193}$$

and the binding energy per nucleon is given by:

$$\frac{I_A}{A} = \frac{Zm_p + (A - Z)m_n - m_A}{A} \tag{194}$$

Here is a table of the binding energy per nucleon for light nuclei:

Nucleus	Z	A	I/A (MeV)
${}^2\text{H}$ (deuteron)	1	2	1.11
${}^3\text{H}$ (triton)	1	3	2.83
${}^3\text{He}$	2	3	2.57
${}^4\text{He}$	2	4	7.07
${}^6\text{Li}$	3	6	5.33
${}^7\text{Li}$	3	7	5.61
${}^9\text{Be}$	4	9	6.46
${}^{11}\text{B}$	5	11	6.93
${}^{12}\text{C}$	6	12	7.68
${}^{16}\text{O}$	8	16	7.98

We can see that the binding energy per nucleon of helium-4 is a local maximum. Thus, we may expect in the limit of time for reaction (due to universe is expanding and cooling down), the most abundant nucleus should be helium-4, which is consistent with the observation.

And time is not enough for the reaction to produce heavier nuclei, thus we don't have C, O, etc. in that stage.

7.2.2 Producing of Deuterium

To produce all other nuclei, we need to first produce deuterium. The reaction is:



However, in the begining BBN as the neutrons just freeze out, the temperature is too high, that even if the deuterium is produced, it will be immediately destroyed by the high energy photons. The reaction of creating deuterium can be viewed as not happening.

As temperature goes lower, the deuterium can survive. Thus, here we want to calculate the temperature at which deuterium can survive and being generated, this will be the beginning of nuclear reaction.

To do this we need assumptions:

1. We assume equilibrium holds. This is the same as we think as long as the reaction happens (deuterium survives), it happens fast enough to maintain equilibrium.
2. We assume only this nuclei reaction happens and turn off the others.

With equilibrium assumed, we can use the Saha equation to calculate the number density of deuterium, and we take the temperature that :

$$\frac{N_D}{N_n} \sim 1 \quad (196)$$

as the temperature at which deuterium can survive and being generated.

The Saha equation for the above reaction is:

$$\frac{N_n N_p}{N_D} = \left(\frac{m_p T}{2\pi} \right)^{3/2} e^{I_D/T} \quad (197)$$

We can use the relation that $N_p = \eta N_\gamma$ and $N_\gamma \sim T^3$, and I_D is the binding energy of deuterium $I_D \sim 2.23$ MeV. Thus one can calculate the temperature at which deuterium can survive and being generated:

$$\frac{N_n}{N_D} \sim 1 \rightarrow T_{NS} \sim 70 \text{ keV} \quad (198)$$

we can see this happens much later than the freeze out of neutron to proton conversion, which is around 0.8 MeV.

Notice that we assume that the neutrons have already freezed out. However, in fact during the time after neutrons freeze out and deuterium can survive, the neutrons may decay. The actual neutron to proton ratio at the time of deuterium survival is around 1/7 instead of 1/5.

7.2.3 Helium-4 Abundance (Rough Estimation)

After deuterium is produced, the reaction can go on and on. As we analyzed before, the most abundant nucleus should be helium-4. We can make a rough estimation that all neutrons are used to produce helium-4, thus determines the abundance of helium-4.

First we have to define a quantity that capture the abundance of a nucleus:

Definition 7.2

Abundance of Nucleus

The abundance of a nucleus is defined as :

$$x_A = \frac{AN_A}{N_b} \quad \sum_A x_A = 1 \quad (199)$$

where N_b is the number density of baryons, and A is number of baryons in the nucleus, and N_A is the number density of the nucleus.

This means how many percentage of baryons come and form a certain nucleus.

Then if we assume all neutrons are used to produce helium-4, then we have:

$$x_{\text{He}} = \frac{4N_{\text{He}}}{N_b} = \frac{4N_n}{N_b} \quad (200)$$

we already know that $\frac{N_n}{N_p} \sim 1/7$ at the time of deuterium survival, and also by definition $N_p + N_n = N_b$, thus we can calculate the abundance of helium-4:

$$x_{\text{He}} \sim \frac{4}{2} \frac{1/7}{1 + 1/7} \sim 0.25 \quad (201)$$

This gives an answer to the result used in recombination that the abundance of helium-4 is around 25% and the abundance of protons is around 75%.

7.2.4 Saha Equation for Nuclear Reaction

We want to make a more precise calculation of the abundance for all nuclei. To do this, we still make assumptions of equilibrium for all reactions. And view the reaction as a whole, we can write the reaction as:

$$Zp + (A - Z)n \leftrightarrow {}^A\text{Nucleus} + \gamma \quad (202)$$

Then we use can derive a Saha equation for the reaction. Equilibrium means that the chemical potential of the reaction should satisfy:

$$Z\mu_p + (A - Z)\mu_n = \mu_A \quad (203)$$

this gives us a Saha equation for the reaction:

Theorem 7.3

Saha Equation for Nuclear Reaction

The Saha equation for the nuclear reaction is given by:

$$N_A = N_p^Z N_n^{A-Z} 2^{-A} g_A A^{3/2} \left(\frac{2\pi}{m_p T} \right)^{\frac{3}{2}(A-1)} e^{I_A/T}, \quad (204)$$

where I_A is the binding energy of the nucleus, and g_A is the degeneracy of the nucleus.

This equation can be written in terms of abundance:

$$x_A = x_p^Z x_n^{A-Z} N_b^{A-1} 2^{-A} g_A A^{5/2} \left(\frac{2\pi}{m_p T} \right)^{\frac{3}{2}(A-1)} e^{I_A/T}. \quad (205)$$

and we know that the number density of baryons is given by:

$$N_b = \eta N_\gamma = \eta \left(2 \frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} \right) T^3 \quad (206)$$

Bibliography

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